



At the start of every year, the Japanese weather office monitors the temperature and conditions to try to predict when the cherry trees, called *sakura*, will bloom. The trees blossom first in the warmer south of Japan, and the “blossom front” spreads up the country, moving north as spring advances. The blossom forecasts are important

because thousands of people celebrate flower-viewing parties, a Japanese tradition, known as *hanami*, that dates back to the 8th century. The trees will carry their blossoms for only a week or two, and people need to plan their festivities. In Japanese culture, the cherry tree’s short-lived bloom is often associated with the fragility of human life.